Still Interested, Yet Exhausted: Study Interest, Academic Burnout, and the Quality of Persistence in Psychology Students

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"Sukailah jurusan Psikologi seperti kau menyukai seseorang yang kau cintai.
Meski terkadang melelahkan, selalu ada alasan untuk tetap bertahan."
— Azis Kurniawan

Abstract. Study interest, academic burnout, and persistence are related but distinct aspects of university experience. This conceptual analysis brings together interest-development theory, self-determination theory, and selected published findings to examine how psychology students can remain interested in their discipline while experiencing academic exhaustion. It distinguishes disciplinary interest from major satisfaction and interest–major fit, exhaustion from cynicism, and autonomous commitment from persistence sustained by pressure. The proposed interest–strain–persistence framework separates intentions from enrollment behavior and places both within the context of educational demands and resources. No original or simulated data are presented. The article's contribution is an interpretive framework and a set of propositions for empirical investigation, not a validated causal model. Its central implication is that continued enrollment should not be taken as sufficient evidence of well-being: understanding persistence also requires attention to students' available resources and reasons for continuing.

Keywords: study interest; academic burnout; psychology students; motivation; persistence

1. Introduction

Choosing psychology because its subject matter is compelling does not ensure that studying it will remain sustainable. An interest in human behavior can coexist with demanding assessments, depleted energy, and uncertainty about academic progress. These experiences do not necessarily indicate a mistaken choice of major or insufficient commitment. Published interest–burnout profiles include students who retain relatively high interest while experiencing exhaustion and perceived inadequacy (Asikainen et al., 2022).

Continued enrollment can be mistaken for well-being, exhaustion for rejection of the discipline, and interest for protection against excessive demands. This article distinguishes what students find engaging, the strain they experience, and their reasons for continuing. Its contribution is conceptual clarification, not the discovery of previously unstudied relationships.

2. Conceptual approach

A purposive, non-systematic synthesis of selected theoretical accounts, primary studies, and meta-analytic evidence clarifies construct boundaries, challenges a simple protective-interest explanation, and develops propositions for future research.

Coverage is not exhaustive, and some interpretations rely on abstracts or publisher previews rather than complete articles. No participants were recruited, no original or simulated participant data were analyzed, and no effect sizes were pooled. The proposed relationships remain untested.

3. Interest, strain, and persistence

3.1. Attraction is not satisfaction or fit

Interest concerns attraction to disciplinary content. The four-phase model distinguishes triggered and maintained situational interest from emerging and well-developed individual interest (Hidi and Renninger, 2006). Enjoying a particular class therefore does not establish an enduring interest in every part of a degree.

Major satisfaction evaluates an educational choice or experience; interest–major fit concerns correspondence between personal interests and program content. A student may therefore remain interested in psychology while becoming dissatisfied with its teaching conditions.

Initial attraction and ongoing motivation require separate measurement. Messerer et al. (2023) linked intrinsic enrollment motivation to subsequent intrinsic learning motivation and, through learning motivation, to lower dropout intention, but not actual dropout. Initial enthusiasm, current motivation, intentions, and enrollment behavior are therefore not equivalent. Retrospective accounts cannot substitute for measurement at entry.

3.2. Exhaustion is not cynical withdrawal

Academic burnout is commonly measured through exhaustion, cynicism, and reduced efficacy or perceived inadequacy. These concern depleted energy, distancing from study meaning, and feeling ineffective, respectively. Curiosity about psychology can persist despite insufficient energy for coursework. This differs from finding the degree meaningless or doubting one's competence. Occasional fatigue alone does not establish sustained burnout.

Asikainen et al. (2022) found that interest and relevance were more strongly associated with lower cynicism than with lower exhaustion. Their interested–inefficacious profile combined positive study experiences with above-average exhaustion and inadequacy. These cross-sectional profiles were sample-relative, not diagnostic.

The findings support the possibility that interest and strain coexist, but they do not establish that interest protects students from burnout. The interest measure also included meaningfulness, creating potential overlap with cynicism items. Differences between the associations may therefore reflect both substantive distinctions and shared measurement content.

3.3. Staying can reflect different motives

Self-determination theory distinguishes intrinsic enjoyment from identified regulation, through which students personally endorse an activity's value, and controlled forms of regulation involving pressure or self-evaluative contingencies (Ryan and Deci, 2020). A difficult course may be valued without being enjoyable. Likewise, interest in psychology can coexist with fear of failure or a desire for approval.

Howard et al. (2021) found that intrinsic motivation was associated with success and well-being, while identified regulation was particularly associated with persistence. Introjected regulation was associated with persistence but also with indicators of ill-being. Continued study therefore does not, by itself, demonstrate autonomous commitment or psychological health. Nor do these findings imply that controlled motives invariably cause burnout.

Educational conditions remain essential to this interpretation. Jagodics and Szabó (2023) reported associations between study demands, resources, and burnout in a Hungarian university sample. Interest may be a motivational asset, but it cannot replace manageable workloads, supportive feedback, or opportunities for recovery.

Research involving Portuguese psychology students also identified relationships between burnout and psychological and sleep-related measures (Pereira et al., 2025). Its single-university, cross-sectional design does not establish that psychology students face greater burnout risk than students in other disciplines. Psychology is a relevant setting for examining these relationships, not an established exceptional-risk population.

4. Implications and limitations

The interest–strain–persistence framework organizes four propositions for future investigation: (1) interest may relate differently to cynicism and exhaustion; (2) retained interest may coexist with increasing exhaustion within individual students; (3) controlled motives may accompany continued study even when disciplinary interest remains; and (4) associations with persistence intentions may differ from associations with actual enrollment behavior.

These are proposed extensions, not empirical findings or validated student categories. Their value depends on improving explanation beyond existing accounts.

Prospective studies should repeatedly assess interest and burnout, separate between-student differences from within-student change, and examine item overlap. Post-entry interest should not be relabeled interest at enrollment. Measuring motivational quality alongside authorized enrollment follow-up can clarify whether intentions translate into behavior. Most studies reviewed by Madigan and Glandorf (2026) measured dropout intentions; only three assessed direct dropout measures.

Advising should ask separately about disciplinary attraction, energy, meaning, and reasons for continuing. Interested but exhausted students may need workload coordination or recovery, not greater enthusiasm. Transfer or interruption can represent informed reconsideration rather than failure. These are reasoned implications, not demonstrated intervention effects.

The selective, non-systematic synthesis spans different countries, disciplines, and measures. Limited full-text access constrains interpretation. No original data test the framework, and findings cannot be generalized directly to Indonesian psychology students. Causal direction, cultural applicability, and explanatory value remain uncertain. Shared measurement content and unmeasured educational conditions offer alternative explanations.

5. Conclusion

Remaining interested while exhausted is conceptually coherent. Understanding this experience requires separating disciplinary attraction, academic strain, motivational quality, and persistence behavior. The proposed framework brings these distinctions together without treating continued enrollment as proof of well-being or interest as sufficient protection against burnout.

Students need not endure because they once loved their major. Educational support should recognize that valued commitment, depleted capacity, and legitimate reconsideration can coexist.

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